

Serbia



Formerly the most powerful republic within Yugoslavia and now an independent nation.

168 BCE The Romans subjugate the Illyrians. By 9 CE the territory is divided and renamed Pannonia and Moesia. The Western Roman Empire declines in the 4th century and the territory is conquered, in turn, by the Eastern Roman Empire (the Byzantines), the Huns and Bulgars, and the Avars, who bring Slavs to the area as vassals.

626 CE The Byzantine Empire defeats the Avars and takes over much of Serbia.

879 Croats in the north and west break away from Byzantium and turn to Catholic Rome, but are invaded by Hungary in 1089. Eastern Orthodox Serbs in the south and west become part of the Bulgarian Empire at the beginning of the 900s but gain some autonomy under Stephen Vojislav in the 1030s.

1101 Civil war breaks out in Serbia after the death of King Constantin Bodin.

1165 The Nemanjic dynasty establishes a Serbian empire, which lasts until the death of King Stefan Uros V in 1371.

1389 The Battle of Kosovo Polje means the end of Serbian independence, as Prince Lazar Hrebljanovic is defeated by the Ottoman Turks.

1459 The Turks complete the conquest of the former Serbian Empire.

1699 The Ottoman Empire is forced to cede Croatia and most of northern Serbia to Austria-Hungary under the Treaty of Karlowitz, after failing to capture Vienna. The Ottomans recapture Serbia in 1739.

1804 Anti-Turkish revolts, led by Karageorge, break out in Serbia, and last until 1813 when they are crushed.

1817 Milos Orbenovic, leader of an insurrection against Ottoman rule since 1815, achieves autonomy for Serbia within the Ottoman Empire.

1829 Serbian autonomy is established by the Treaty of Adrianople, which ends a Russo-Turkish war. Milos Obrenovic is recognized as hereditary prince of autonomous Serbia. He attempts to expand Serbia, before abdicating in 1839 in the face of opposition. A period of factional fighting is followed by a coup in 1842 that brings Alexander Karageorgevic (son of Karageorge) to power.

1858 Milos returns to power after Alexander Karageorgevic is deposed. His son Michael succeeds him in attempting to modernize the Serbian government, before being assassinated in 1868.

1876 Serbia and Montenegro declare war on Turkey in support of Bosnian

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE BATTLE OF KOSOVO, 1389

Here, Serb cavalry make an ill-fated charge toward the Turkish lines at the Battle of Kosovo, which resulted in a Serb rout on June 28, 1389. The defeat ended Serb independence for almost 500 years, but Kosovo has remained the heartland of Serb nationalism ever since, even though the region today has fewer than 100,000 Serbs living among two million Kosovo Albanians. Such nationalist sentiments explain the brutal Serbian reaction to growing calls for an independent Kosovo in the 1990s.



insurrectionists. Russia declares war in their support in 1877 and, after the Turkish defeat, Serbia becomes an independent principality under the Treaty of San Stefano. Under the 1878 Treaty of Berlin, Serbia loses some territory back to Turkey but gains land in the southeast from Bulgaria. A period of nationalist and international conflict follows in the region.

1882 Prince Milan Obrenovic is proclaimed king.

1903 Serbian king Alexander is murdered by officers in his Belgrade palace after years of factionalism and corruption in government which began during the reign of his father, King Milan. His successor, King Peter, begins liberalization and allows parliamentary government.

1908 Austria-Hungary annexes Bosnia, with tacit Russian agreement. Serbia protests but, without its Russian ally's support, can do nothing.

1912 First Balkan War begins after Serbia, Montenegro, Bulgaria, and Greece form the Balkan League and declare war on Turkey. Serbia increases its territory to the south after the defeat of Turkey, and then gains more land from Bulgaria after its defeat in Second Balkan War of 1913.

1914 World War I is triggered by the assassination by Gavrilo Princip, a Serbian revolutionary, of the Austrian archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Austrian throne, in Sarajevo. An Austrian ultimatum is rejected by Serbia and the war between them spreads across Europe.

1918 Serbian king Alexander Karageorgevic unites the weakened Serbia, Montenegro, and Slovenia into the Kingdom of Serbs, Croats, and Slovenes, after the defeat of Austria-Hungary.

1920 Elections to a Constituent Assembly result in a centrist government led by the Serbian Nikola Pasic. A unitary constitution, promulgated in 1921, is consistently opposed by Croat parliamentarians.

1929 Alexander imposes a dictatorship to end Serbian, Croatian, and Slovene

nationalism and renames the country Yugoslavia. However his rule merely increases Serbian domination, bureaucracy, and repression by the police.

1934 Alexander is assassinated in France. Yugoslavia is ruled by regents on behalf of the child king Peter.

1941 Germany invades Yugoslavia after the overthrow of a Yugoslav government, which had signed the Tripartite Pact with the Axis powers, and its replacement with a pro-British alternative. The country is partitioned. Rival partisan groups resist the Nazis—Serbian royalist Cetniks and the communist Partisans under Josef Tito, Communist Party of Yugoslavia leader.

1942 Communists set up an Anti-Fascist National Liberation Council, which becomes the provisional government in 1943 and takes power after the Nazi defeat in 1945.

1945 Tito's provisional government abolishes the monarchy and in 1946 proclaims the Federal People's Republic of Yugoslavia with six constituent republics, including Serbia. The majority Albanian region of Kosovo and the Hungarian-speaking province of Vojvodina in the north are given the status of autonomous regions within Serbia.

1948 Tito takes Yugoslavia out of the Soviet bloc after he is accused of "nationalist deviationism" over his reluctance to allow Yugoslavia to become a Moscow satellite. A Soviet economic blockade is imposed. Tito seeks economic help from the US and Western Europe.

1953 Bicameral National Assembly adopts new constitution guaranteeing sovereignty to the six Yugoslav republics.

1980 After the death of Tito, Yugoslavia begins to unravel as nationalist tensions, and rivalry between Serbs and Croats rise to the surface of politics.

1987 Slobodan Milosevic becomes leader of Serbian Communist Party and, in 1989, president of Serbia.

1988 Yugoslav federal government falls when its budget proposals are defeated in

the parliament. Pressure from Croatia and Slovenia for greater autonomy is opposed by hardliners in Serbia, who demand a strong centralized state.

1990 Referendum in Serbia approves constitutional changes, which end the autonomy of Kosovo and Vojvodina. Unrest follows the implementation of the new constitution.

1990 Elections are held in Macedonia, and later in Bosnia-Herzegovina, which result in nationalist victories. Communists retain power in Serbia and Montenegro.

1991 Croatia and Slovenia proclaim independence, followed by Macedonia. Fighting in Slovenia as the Serb-dominated Yugoslav National Army (JNA) attempts to take control of the republic.

1991 Hostilities begin in Croatia between Serb militants, backed by the JNA, and the Croatian military. The fighting is punctuated by a series of shortlived ceasefires, brokered by the EU.

1991 A rump presidency, comprising Serbia (with Kosovo and Vojvodina) and Montenegro assumes federal power. Yugoslav navy blockades Croatian ports.

1992 Bosnia-Herzegovina proclaims independence; civil war breaks out. UN imposes sanctions on Yugoslavia for its role in provoking the war.

1992 New Federal Republic of Yugoslavia (FRY), consisting of Serbia (with Kosovo and Vojvodina) and Montenegro is formed. Elections in Kosovo, declared illegal by the Serbian authorities, result in victory for a Democratic Alliance of Kosovo, whose leader, Ibrahim Rugova, is elected president and proclaims independence.

1992 Slobodan Milosevic is reelected as Serbian president. His Socialist Party of Serbia (SPS) strengthens its position in the Serbian legislature.

1995 Milosevic signs Bosnian peace accord.

1996 UN sanctions formally lifted.

1997 Concessions made by Milosevic after massive protests, acknowledging malpractice in municipal elections. Milosevic becomes federal president.

1998 Conflict in Kosovo escalates as freedom fighters confront Yugoslav army.

1999 Talks between Kosovan leaders and Yugoslav break down in Paris; Serb "ethnic cleansing" of Kosovan areas precipitates mass exodus. NATO bombs Yugoslav position to force them out of Kosovo, which is now policed by the international force KFOR. Kosovo is now under UN administration.

2000 Defeat of Milosevic in first round of presidential election. Opposition candidate Vojislav Kostunica sweeps to power after anti-Milosevic protests.